IS AUTHORITARIANISM AN INHIBITOR OF POLITICAL ACTIVISM IN DIFFERENT CENTRAL EUROPEAN COUNTRIES?

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Research Question

Does **authoritarianism** predict **political activism** in Eastern Central European countries Germany, The Czech Republic, Hungary, Poland, and Slovakia?

And, if yes, how is this related to people's political orientation?

Sample

Country

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	1 Germany	1074	20.1	20.1	20.1
	2 Czech Republic	1063	19.9	19.9	40.0
	3 Hungary	1082	20.3	20.3	60.3
	4 Poland	1078	20.2	20.2	80.4
	5 Slovakia	1045	19.6	19.6	100.0
	Total	5342	100.0	100.0	

No weighting performed – representative samples

Authoritarianism Items

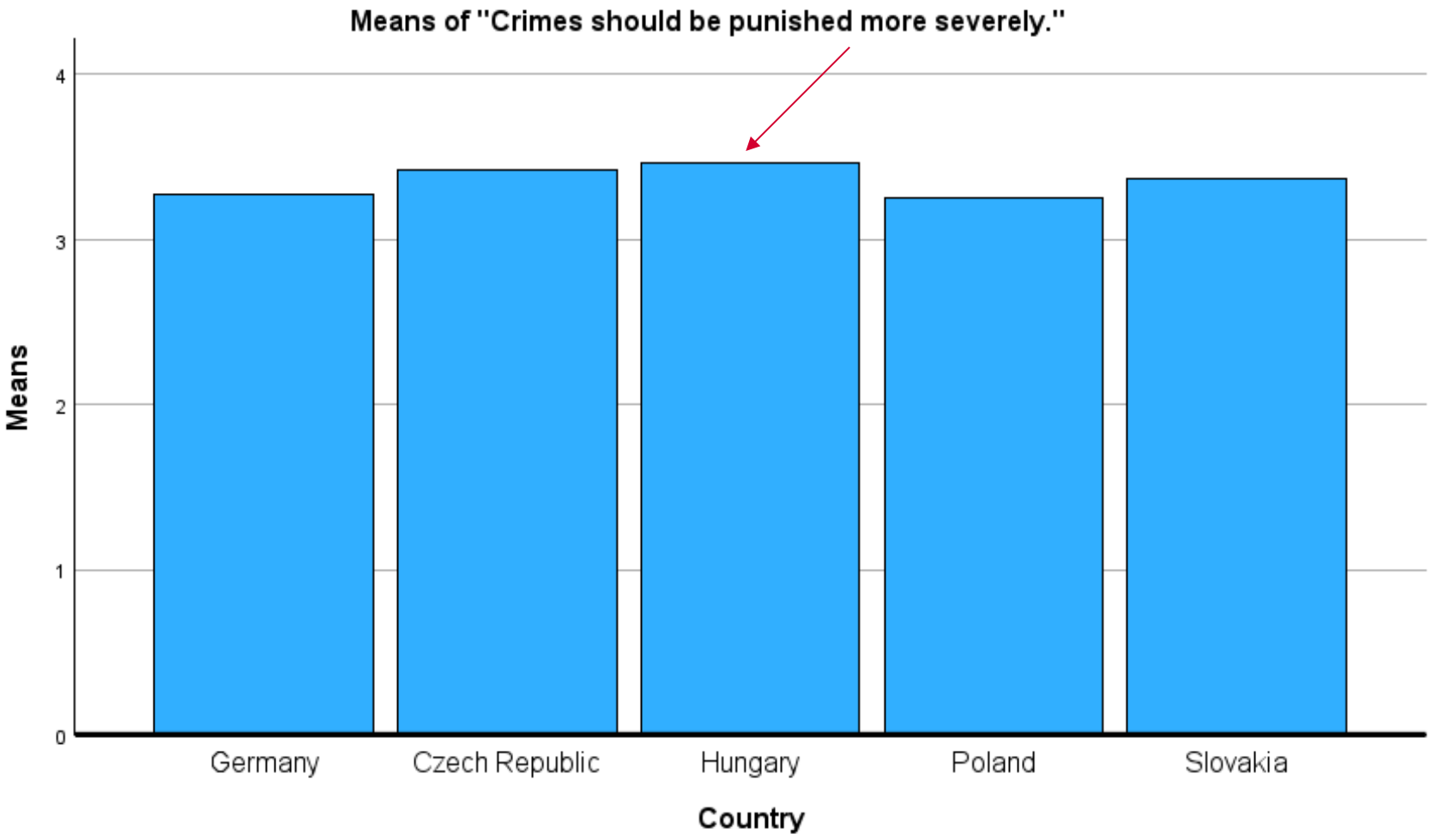
Repressive Authoritarianism

- Crimes should be punished more severely.
- To preserve law and order, outsiders and troublemakers should be pursued more rigorously.

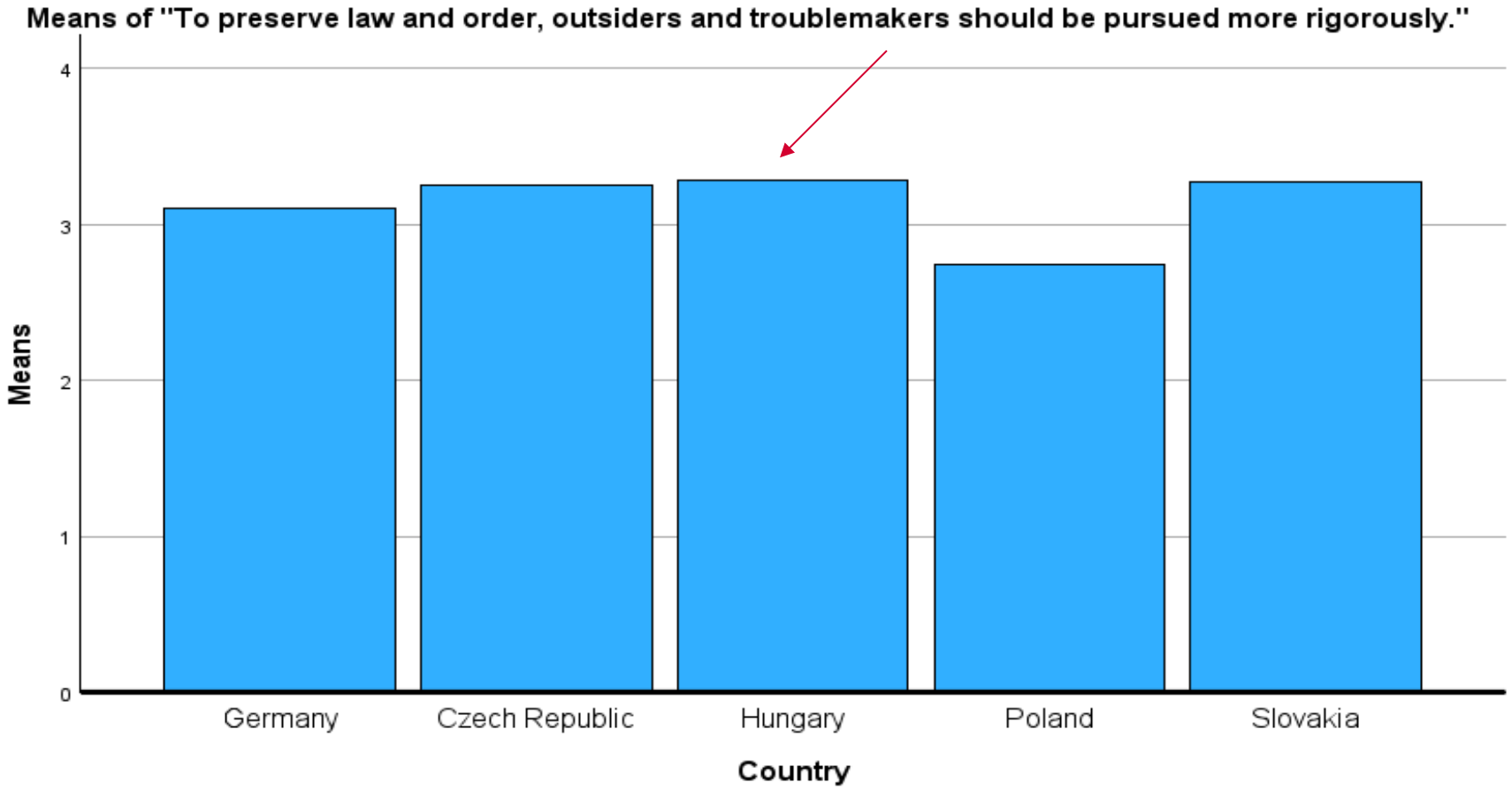
Submissive Authoritarianism

- Some of the most important qualities someone should have are obedience and respect for superiors.
- We should be grateful for leaders who tell us what to do.

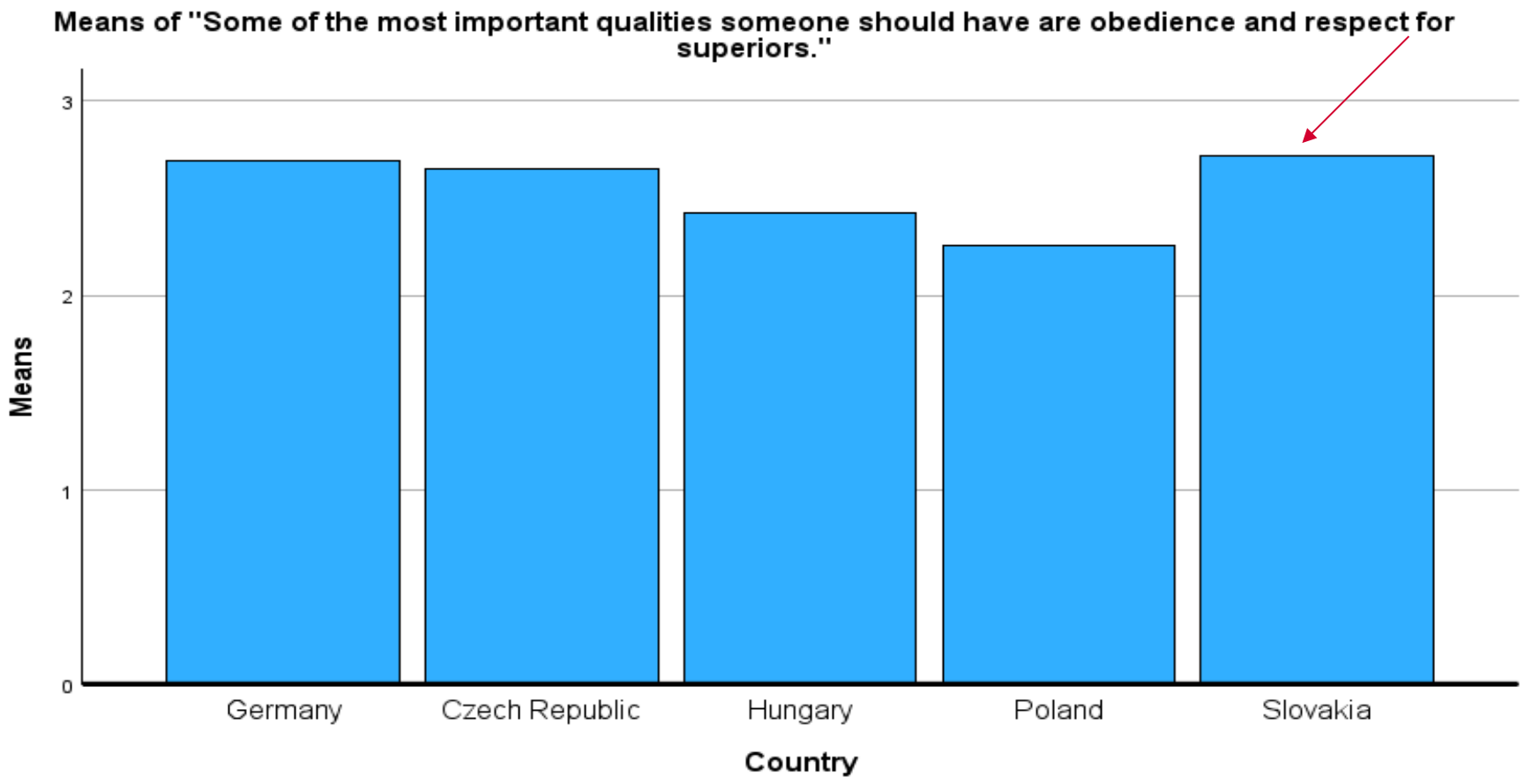
Authoritarianism Items



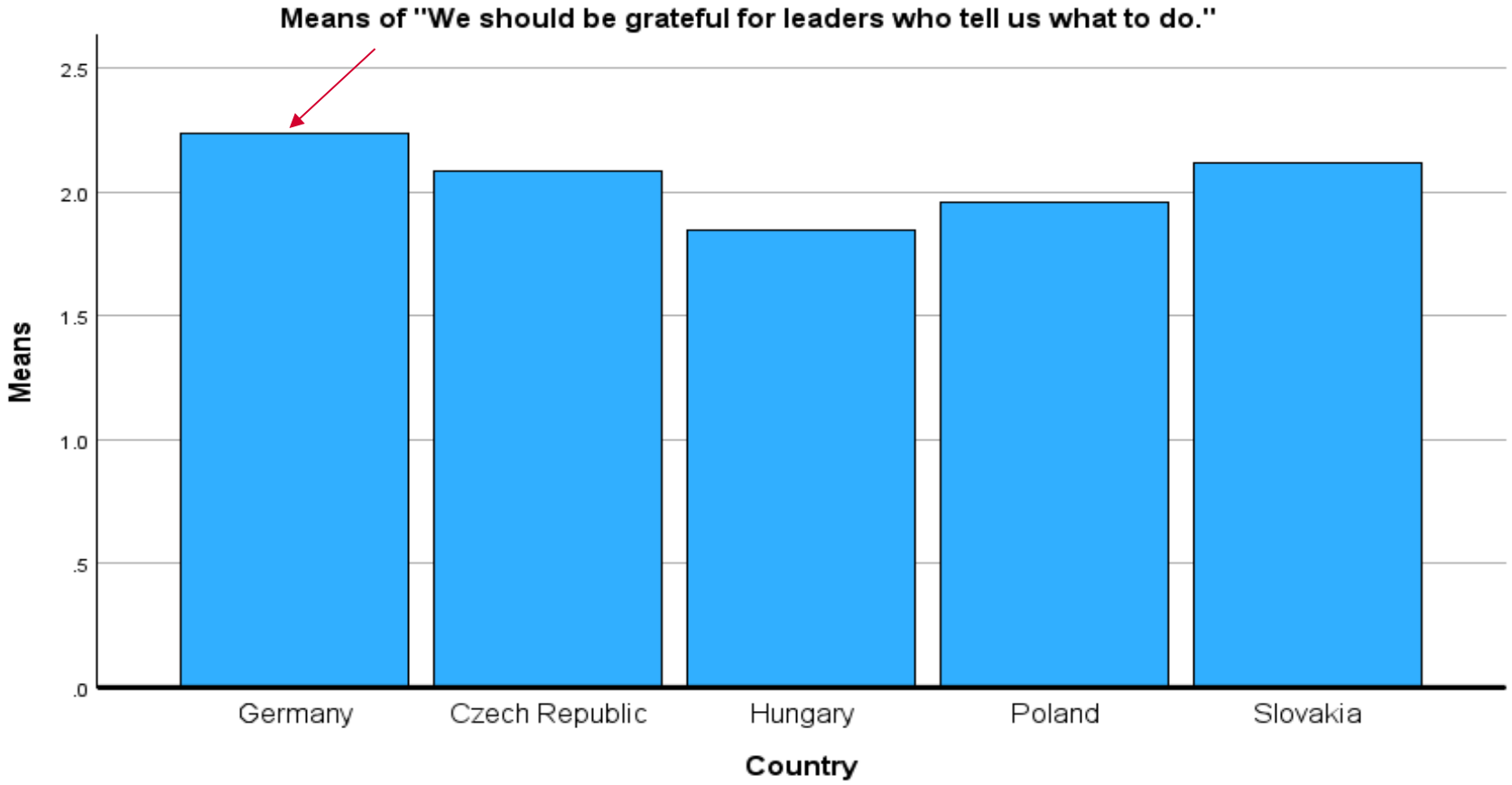
Authoritarianism Items



Authoritarianism Items



Authoritarianism Items



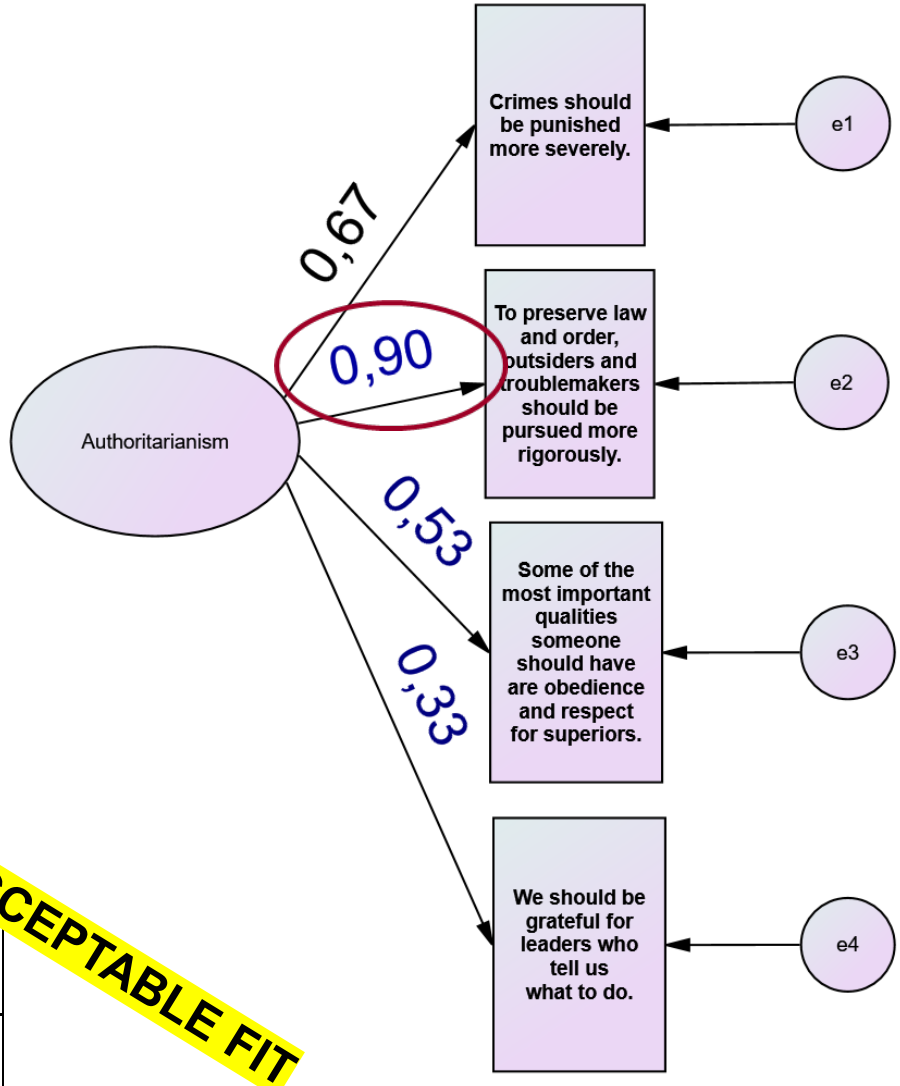
Authoritarianism Items (Consistency)

Cronbach's α		McDonald's ω
.72	Grand Sample	.68
.73	Germany	.72
.71	Czech Republic	.67
.73	Hungary	.68
.72	Poland	.70
.66	Slovakia	.59

Debatable consistency: The lower threshold for 4-item scales is k * .10, where k stands for the number of items, i.e., here .40, but textbooks often speak of .80 as the minimum "reliability" of scales.

Authoritarianism Items
(Grand Sample)

Confirmatory Factor Analysis



Baseline Comparisons

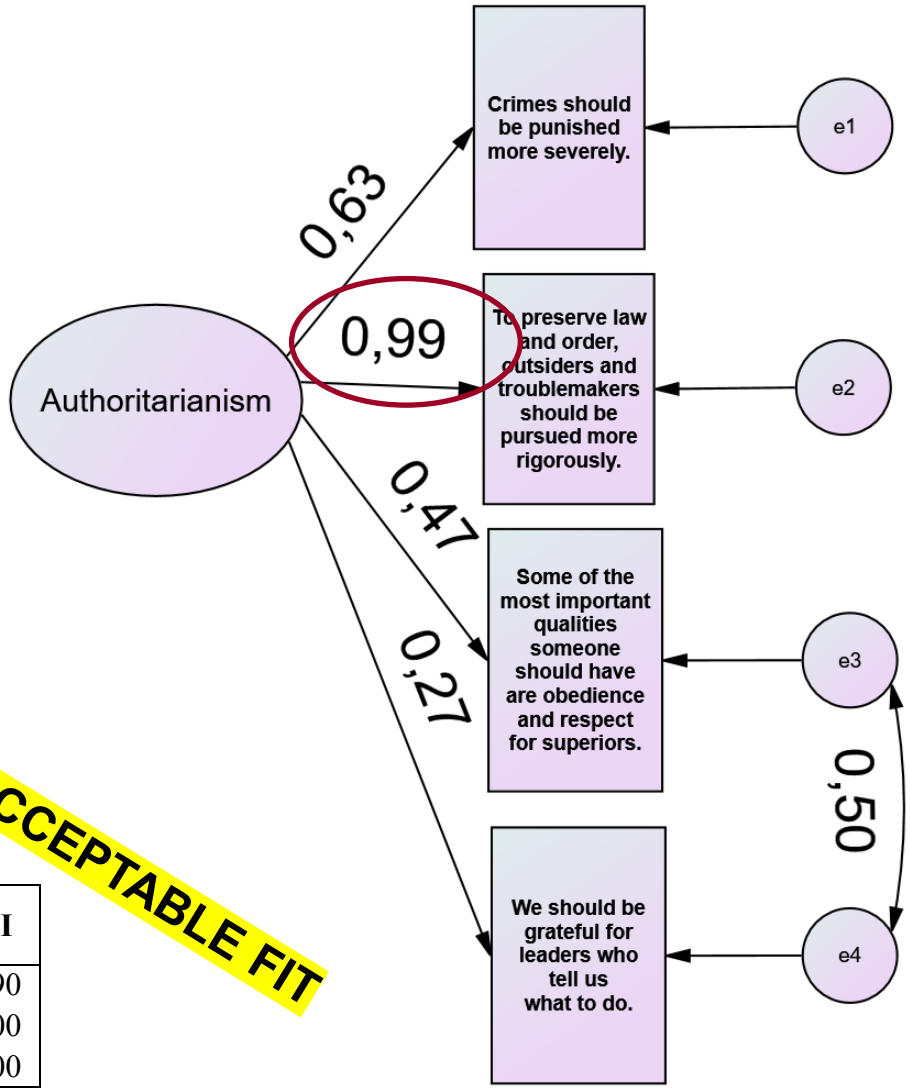
Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	,739	,218	,739	,218	,739
Saturated model	1,000		1,000		1,000
Independence model	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000

UNACCEPTABLE FIT

Authoritarianism Items

(Grand Sample) modified

Confirmatory Factor Analysis



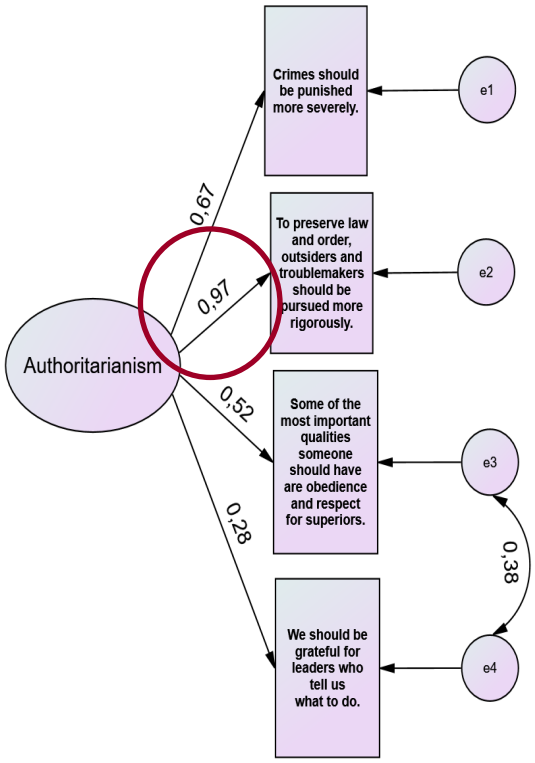
ACCEPTABLE FIT

Baseline Comparisons

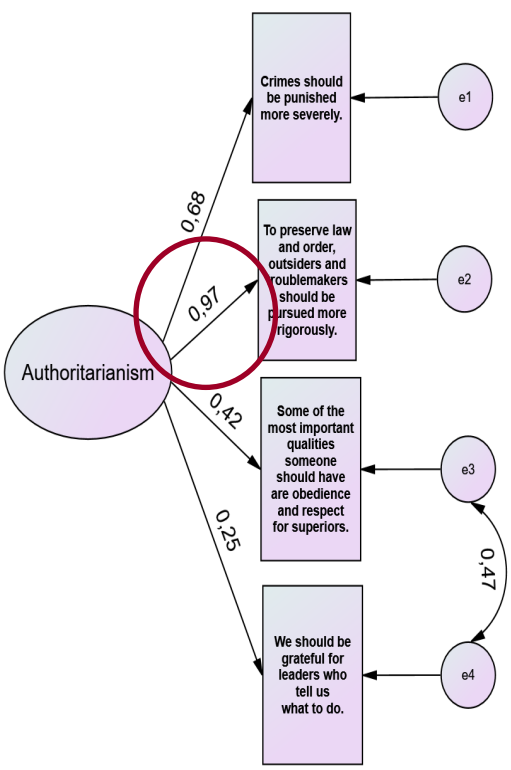
Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	,990	,941	,990	,942	,990
Saturated model	1,000		1,000		1,000
Independence model	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000

Test of Structural Equivalence
(= identical factor structure)

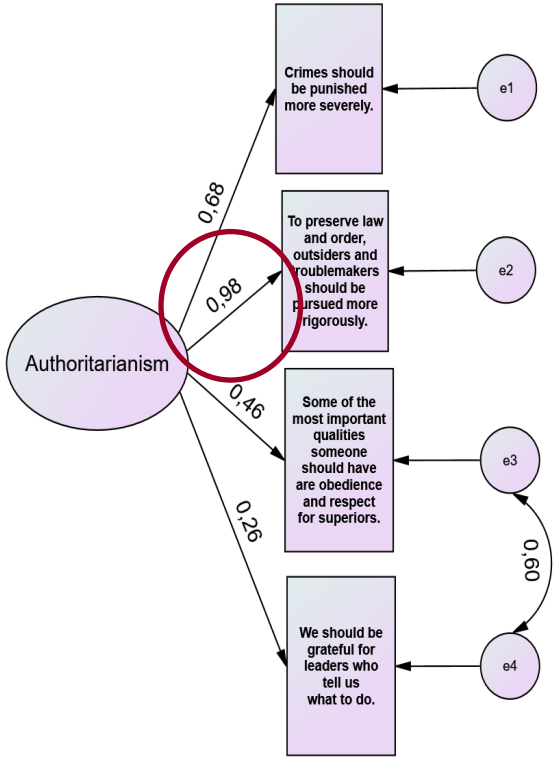
Authoritarianism Items - Confirmatory Factor Analysis



Germany



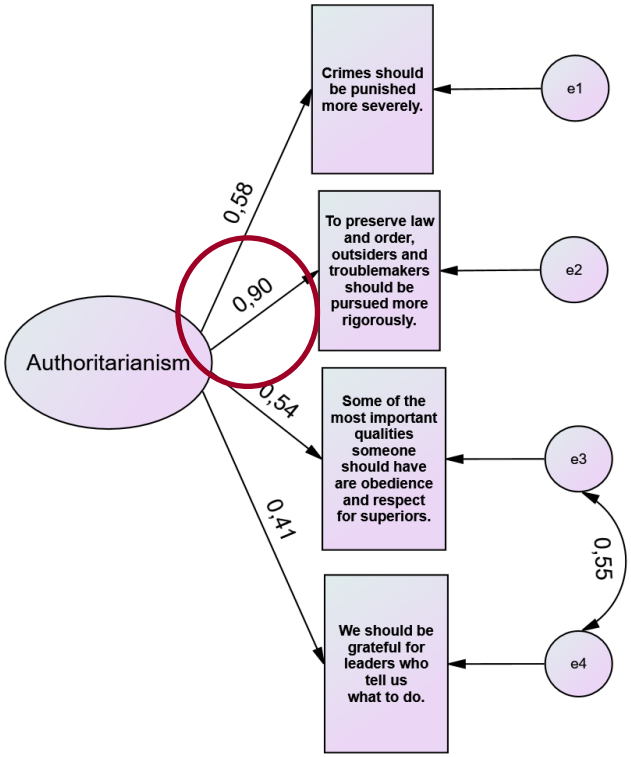
Czech Rep.



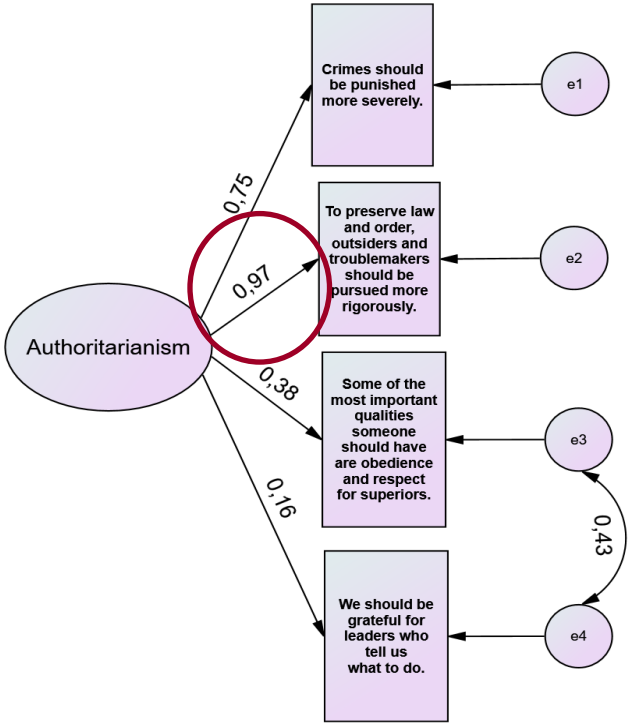
Hungary

Test of Structural Equivalence
(= identical factor structure)

Authoritarianism Items - Confirmatory Factor Analysis



Poland



Slovakia

Authoritarianism Items
(multi-sample fit, test of structural equivalence)

Baseline Comparisons

Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	.983	.937	.985	.942	.985
Saturated model	1.000		1.000		1.000
Independence model	.000	.000	.000	.000	.000

STRUCTURAL EQUIVALENCE ACHIEVED

(= identical factor structure,

i.e., one-factor solution admissible in all countries)

Authoritarianism Items
(multi-sample fit, test of structural and metric equivalence)

Baseline Comparisons

Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	.965	.950	.968	.955	.968
Saturated model	1.000		1.000		1.000
Independence model	.000	.000	.000	.000	.000

STRUCTURAL and METRIC EQUIVALENCE ACHIEVED

(= identical factor structure, identical loading pattern, identical error correlations, admissIble in all countries)

Authoritarianism Items
(multi-sample fit, test of scalar equivalence)

Baseline Comparisons

Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	.852	.891	.857	.896	.857
Saturated model	1.000		1.000		1.000
Independence model	.000	.000	.000	.000	.000

SCALAR EQUIVALENCE NOT ACHIEVED

(= identical error variances of latent and manifest variables NOT achieved)

Authoritarianism Items

Consequence:

- Raw scores cannot be used for cross-national comparisons.

Remedy:

- EMIC measurement of authoritarianism

Statistical Approach:

- Calculate within-country factor scores (= participant-specific scores on the extracted factor)

Political Activism Items

During the last 12 months …

…have you contacted a politician, government, or local government official?
… have you worked in a political party or action group?
… have you worked in another organization or association?
… have you worn or displayed a campaign badge/sticker?
… have you signed a petition?
… have you taken part in a lawful public demonstration?
… have you boycotted certain products?
… have you posted or shared anything about politics online?

Political Activism Items

During the last 12 months …

…have you contacted a politician, government, or local government official?

Collective Activism

… have you worked in a political party or action group?

… have you worked in another organization or association?

… have you worn or displayed a campaign badge/sticker?

… have you signed a petition?

… have you taken part in a lawful public demonstration?

… have you boycotted certain products?

Individual Activism

… have you posted or shared anything about politics online?

Political Activism Items

GERMANY

	Mean
Contact Politician	.1564
Party	.0959
Organization	.1974
Badge	.0996
Petition	.3445
Demonstration	.1490
Boycott	.3454
Online Post	.2207

CZECH REPUBLIC

	Mean
Contact Politician	.1787
Party	.0687
Organization	.1195
Badge	.1383
Petition	.4403
Demonstration	.1637
Boycott	.3509
Online Post	.3481

HUNGARY

	Mean
Contact Politician	.1627
Party	.0444
Organization	.1017
Badge	.0730
Petition	.2532
Demonstration	.1137
Boycott	.2172
Online Post	.2736

POLAND

	Mean
Contact Politician	.1688
Party	.0983
Organization	.1642
Badge	.2199
Petition	.4369
Demonstration	.2199
Boycott	.4147
Online Post	.3043

SLOVAKIA

	Mean
Contact Politician	.1981
Party	.0488
Organization	.1273
Badge	.1005
Petition	.6258
Demonstration	.1703
Boycott	.2756
Online Post	.2191

Political Activism Items (Consistency)

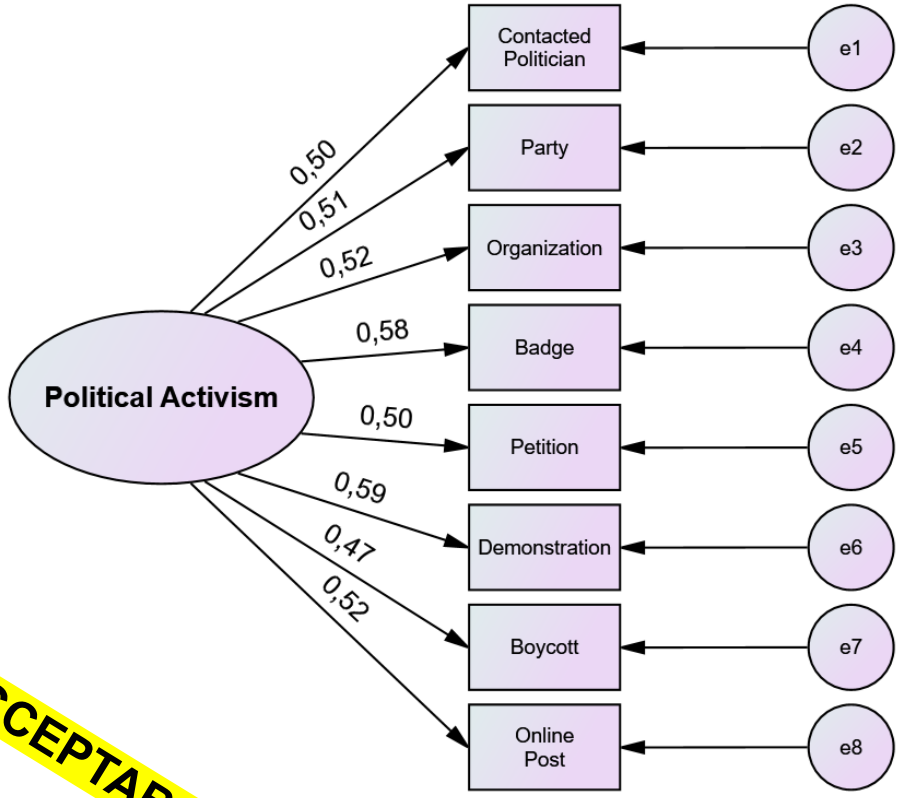
Kuder-Richardson's α		McDonald's ω
.74	Grand Sample	.74
.76	Germany	.75
.69	Czech Republic	.69
.76	Hungary	.76
.78	Poland	.78
.71	Slovakia	.71

Low consistency: The lower threshold for 8-item scales is k * .10, where k stands for the number of items, i.e., here .80, but this is achieved here neither for the grand sample nor for any single country.

Political Activism Items

(Grand Sample)

Confirmatory Factor Analysis



UNACCEPTABLE FIT

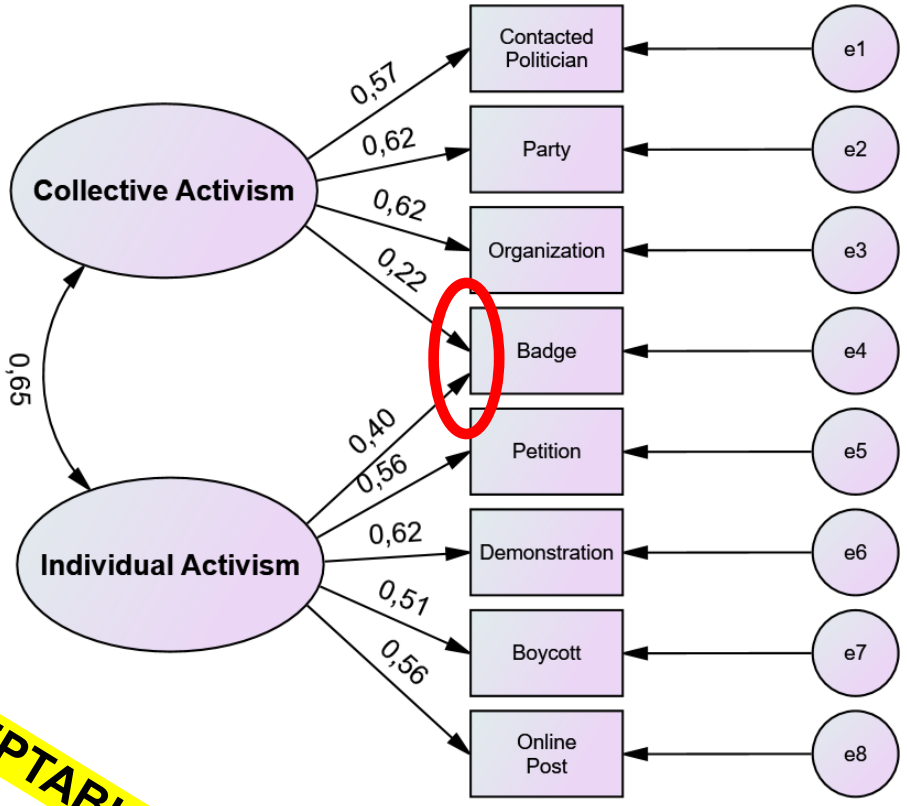
Baseline Comparisons

Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	,890	,846	,893	,849	,892
Saturated model	1,000		1,000		1,000
Independence model	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000

Political Activism Items

(Grand Sample)

Confirmatory Factor Analysis

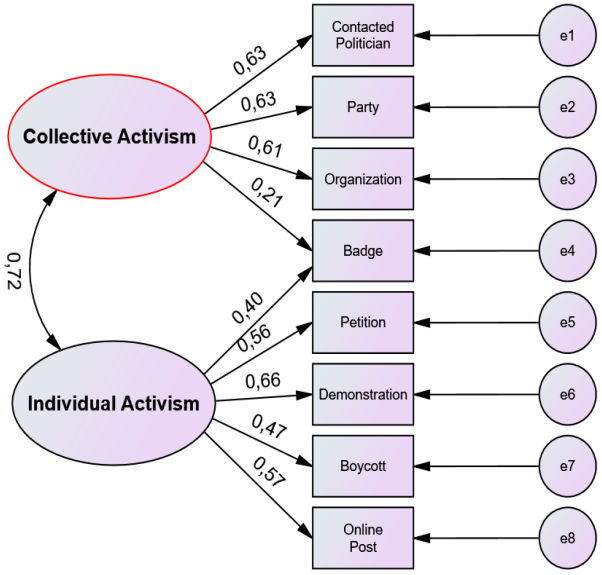


ACCEPTABLE FIT

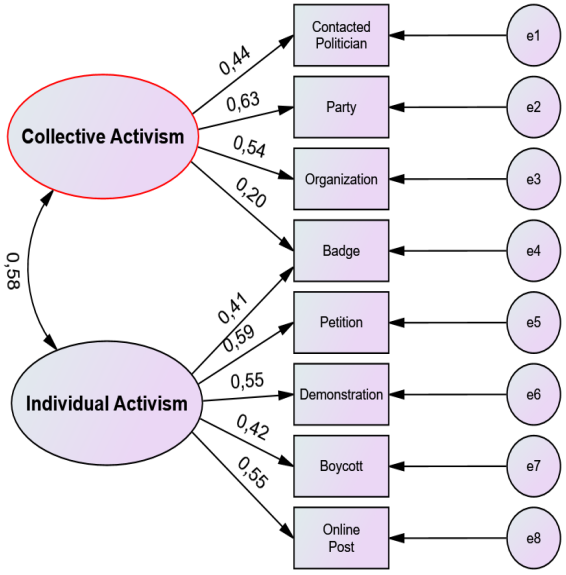
Baseline Comparisons

Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	,967	,948	,969	,952	,969
Saturated model	1,000		1,000		1,000
Independence model	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000

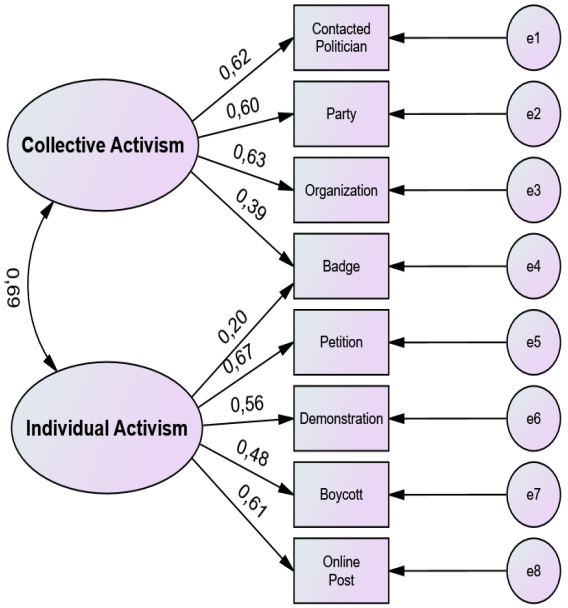
Political Activism Items - Confirmatory Factor Analysis



Germany

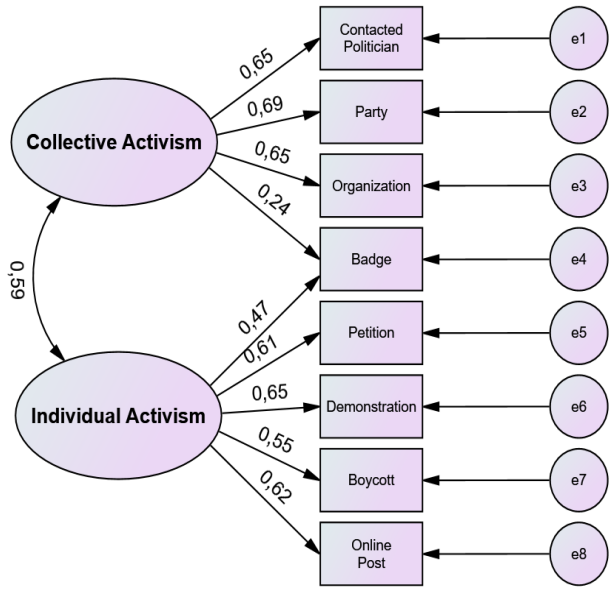


Czech Rep.

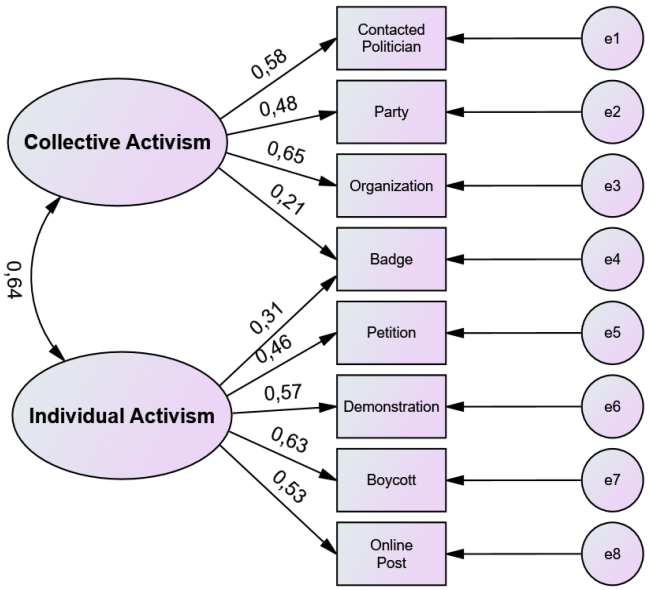


Hungary

Political Activism Items - Confirmatory Factor Analysis



Poland



Slovakia

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Political Activism Items
(multi-sample fit, test of structural equivalence)

Baseline Comparisons

Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	.943	.911	.954	.928	.954
Saturated model	1.000		1.000		1.000
Independence model	.000	.000	.000	.000	.000

STRUCTURAL EQUIVALENCE ACHIEVED

(= identical factor structure,

i.e., two-factor solution admissible in all countries)

Political Activism Items
(multi-sample fit, test of structural and metric equivalence)

Baseline Comparisons

Model	NFI Delta1	RFI rho1	IFI Delta2	TLI rho2	CFI
Default model	.764	.740	.777	.754	.777
Saturated model	1.000		1.000		1.000
Independence model	.000	.000	.000	.000	.000

METRIC EQUIVALENCE NOT ACHIEVED

(= identical two-factorial structure, but different loading pattern)

No need to test for scalar equivalence

Political Activism Items

Consequence:

- Raw scores cannot be used for cross-national comparisons.

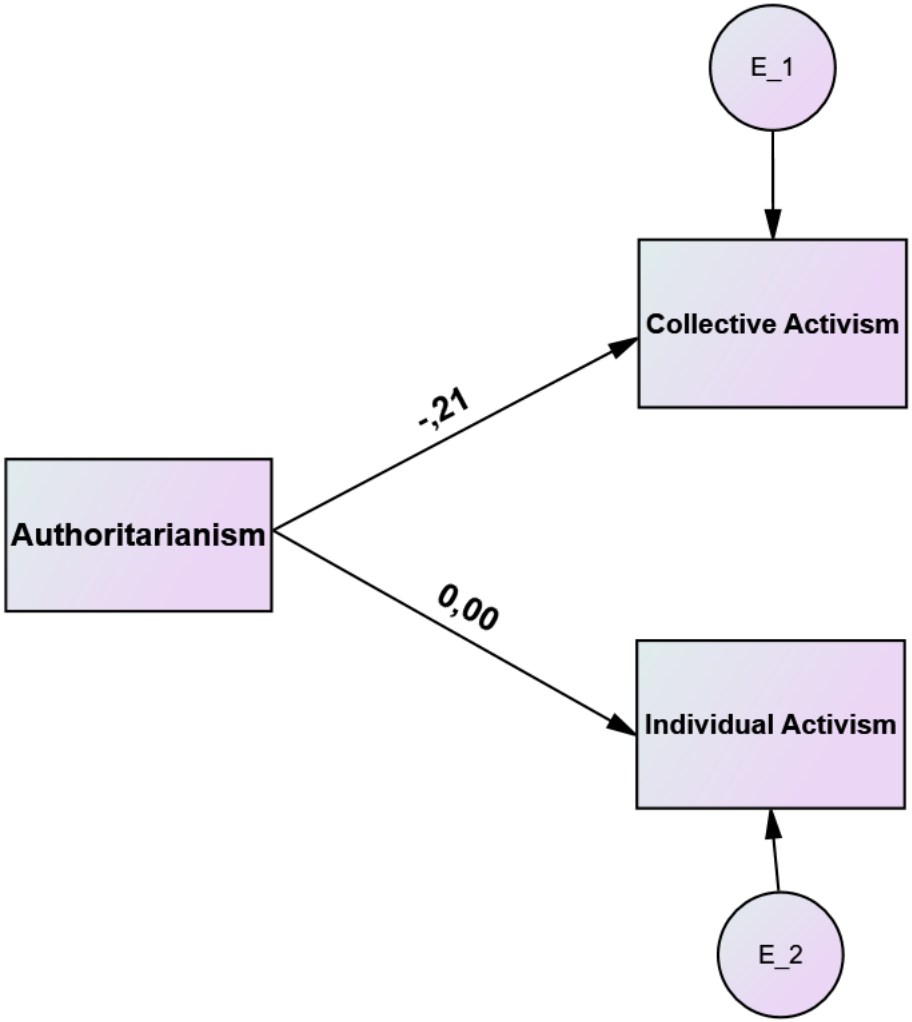
Remedy:

- EMIC measurement of authoritarianism

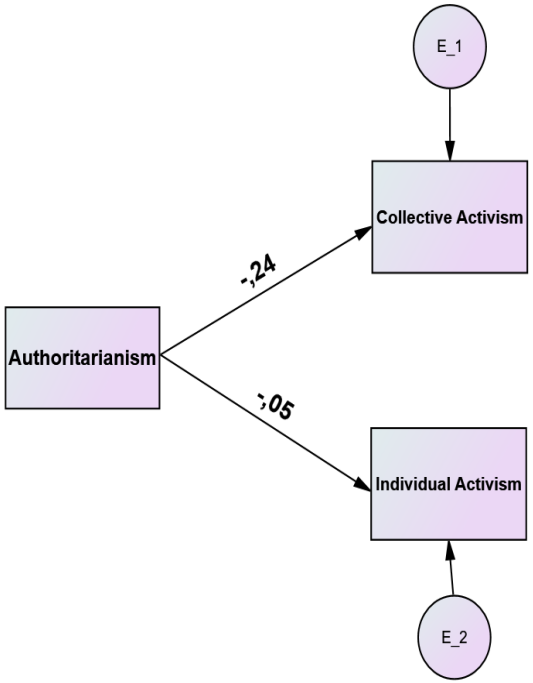
Statistical Approach:

- Calculate within-country factor scores (= participant-specific scores on the extracted TWO factors)

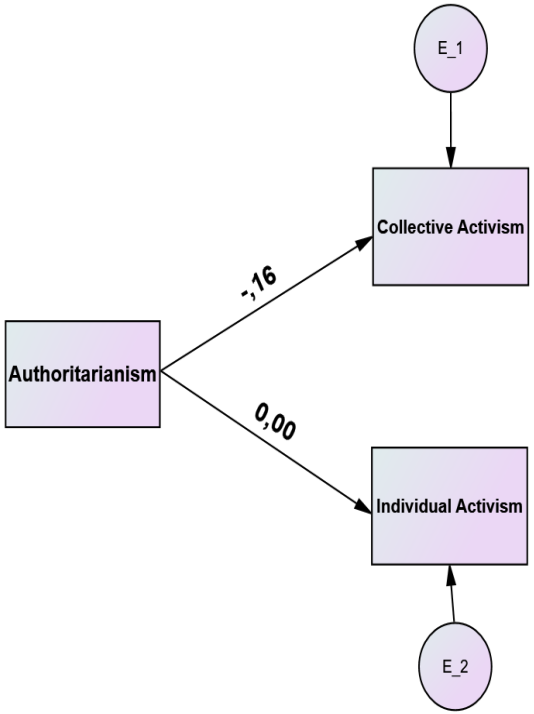
Grand Sample Model Test



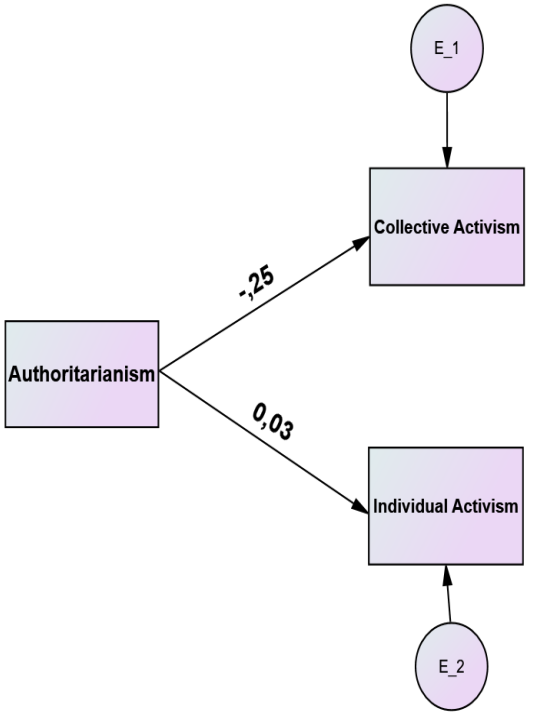
Country-Specific Model Test



Germany

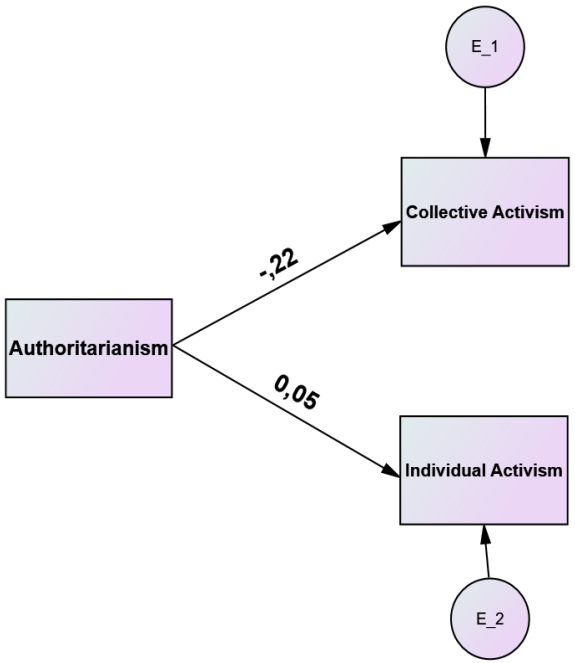


Czech Republic

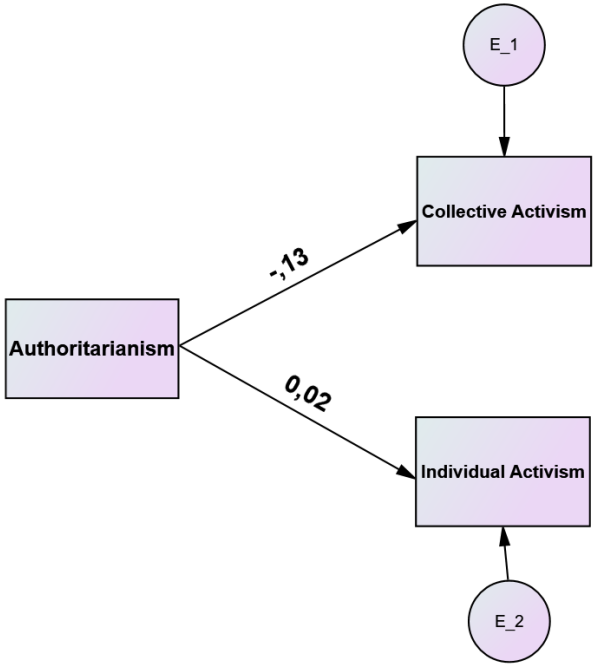


Hungary

Country-Specific Model Test



Poland

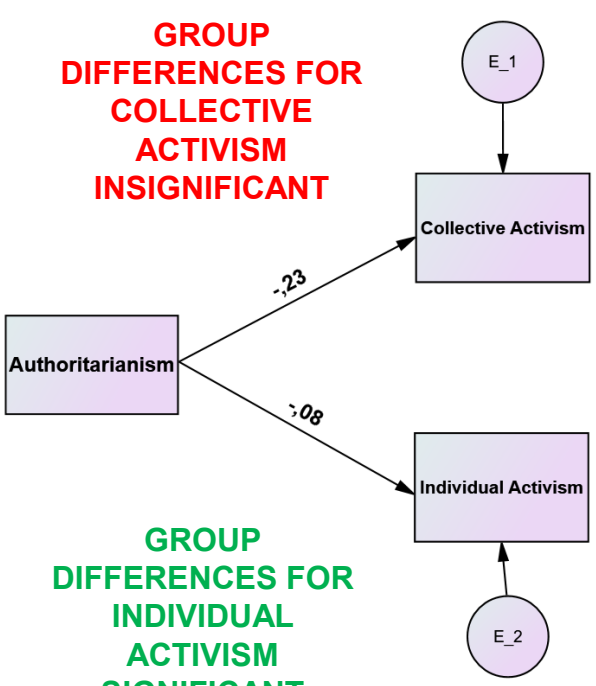


Slovakia

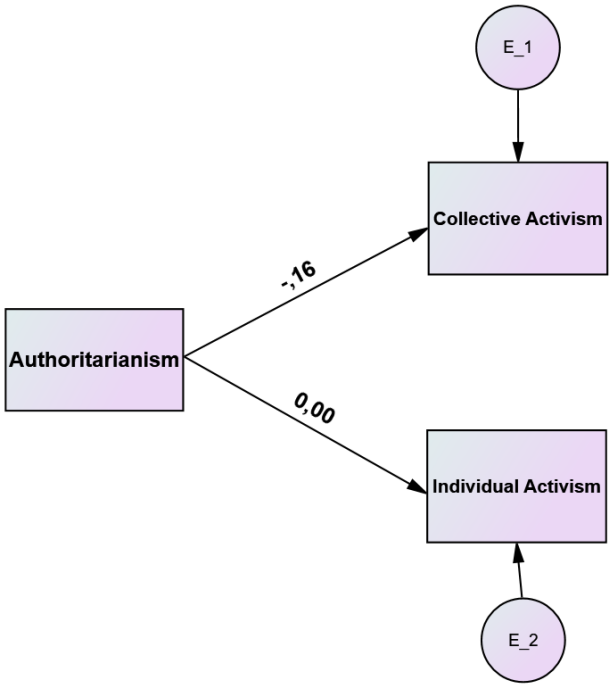
Grand Sample Model Test—Moderated by Political Orientation

GROUP DIFFERENCES FOR COLLECTIVE ACTIVISM INSIGNIFICANT

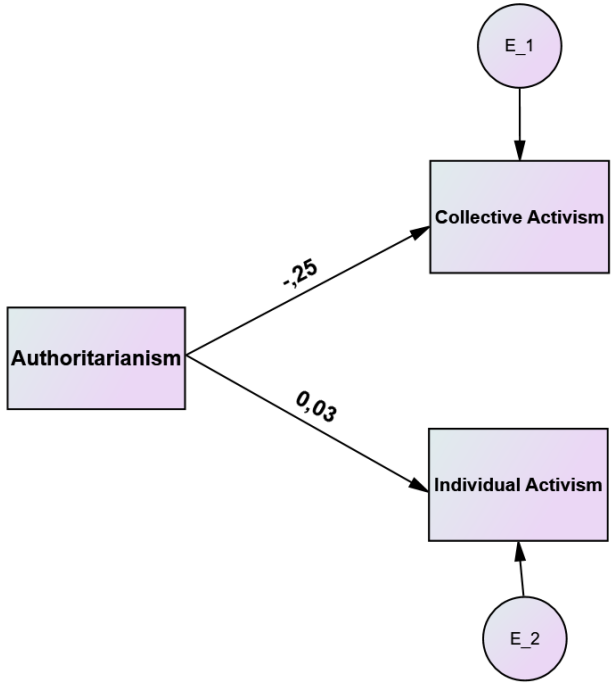
GROUP DIFFERENCES FOR INDIVIDUAL ACTIVISM SIGNIFICANT



left



center



right

Per Country Model Test—Moderated by Political Orientation

Level of Authoritarianism is the Predictor

COUNTRY		D	CZ	HU	PL	SK
	TYPE OF ACTIVISM					
POLITICAL ORIENTATION						
LEFT	COLLECTIVE ACTIVISM	-.29	-.17	-.23	-.24	-.14
	INDIVIDUAL ACTIVISM	-.14	-.06	-.11	-.05	-.08
CENTER	COLLECTIVE ACTIVISM	-.18	-.16	-.26	-.20	-.11
	INDIVIDUAL ACTIVISM	.02	-.02	.02	-.01	.07
RIGHT	COLLECTIVE ACTIVISM	-.08	-.12	-.07	-.13	-.11
	INDIVIDUAL ACTIVISM	-.04	.08	.12	.10	.04

Political Activism Items

Country differences:

- Significant only for the relationship between authoritarianism and individual activism.

Differences by political orientation:

- Only for individual activism: Authoritarianism curbs individual activism among people leaning toward the left in Germany, where it enhances political activism among people leaning toward the right in Hungary.

Conclusion

- Measures **(both authoritarianism and political activism)** were valid within all five countries.
- Raw scores could not be compared across countries; scalar equivalence was not achieved.
- Country-specific factor scores were used.
- Authoritarianism reduced/curbs collective activism.
- Effects on individual activism differed by country and political orientation.
  - German (left): **lower** individual activism.
  - Hungary (right): **higher** individual activism.

Conclusion - Implications

- Effect sizes were **small to moderate**
- Promoting **democratic political efficacy** may increase collective political activism.
- Strategies for **individual political activism** should be adapted to each country's context.
- Reducing authoritarianism is **not equally effective in every country**.

- DANKE FÜR IHRE AUFMERKSAMKEIT
- GRAZIE PER LA TUA ATTENZIONE
- GRACIAS POR SU ATENCIÓN
- СПАСИБО ЗА ВАШЕ ВНИМАНИЕ
- □□□□□□□□□□□□□□
- 感谢您的关注
- SPAS JI BO BALA WE
- THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION

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SUPPLEMENTARY SLIDES

Long Abstract

This contribution is based on large, representative samples from Germany, the Czech Republic, Hungary, Poland, and Slovakia (N > 1000 in each country). The first focus of the presentation lies on whether authoritarianism and political activism can be assessed validly across the five countries using identical instruments. To measure the level of people's authoritarianism, four 'classical' items were used (e.g., 'Crimes should be punished more severely'). To measure people's level of political activism, an instrument comprising eight dichotomous (no/yes) items was used, asking respondents whether they recently had participated in a given political action (e.g., 'During the last 12 months, have you taken part in a lawful public demonstration?'). Both constructs were measured validly within the five countries, but scalar equivalence—necessary for cross-national comparisons—was not reached. The main research question addressed is to what degree authoritarianism ***curbs*** political activism. This question is addressed using structural equation modeling, based on country-specific factor scores of participants on authoritarianism and political activism. SEM analyses show that the relationship between authoritarianism and collective as well as individual political activism (two subconstructs) is strongest in Germany and weakest in Slovakia. Reasons for this finding are explored conceptually and empirically, the latter by partialling for self-rated political orientation on the classical left-right scale. In summary, authoritarianism is a persistent yet relatively weak **NEGATIVE** predictor of political activism across all Central European countries. In Germany, however, the connection is significantly stronger than in both Slovakia and the Czech Republic. Cross-national differences are statistically significant only for the relationship between authoritarianism and individual political activism: authoritarianism curbs it among left-leaning study participants in Germany, whereas enhancing it among right-leaning participants in Hungary.

Conclusion

Both authoritarianism and political activism (two facets) can be assessed validly WITHIN the five countries using the instruments included in the research. However, scores cannot be compared cross-nationally; scalar equivalence is not achieved. Thus, an emic approach to comparisons was used: country-specific factor scores for authoritarianism and for collective and individual political activism were calculated. Results show that authoritarianism curbs collective political activism in all countries and across the entire spectrum of political orientations. For individual political activism, cross-national differences were found, moderated by political leaning, with authoritarianism curbing individual political activism among left-leaning study participants in Germany, whereas in Hungary it enhanced individual political activism among study participants leaning towards the right.

Conclusion - Implications

- The effect sizes of all findings are moderate to low. However, this does not preclude the formulation of a small number of policy recommendations. It is not surprising to incur small effect sizes in representative-sample studies:

- Fostering democratic political efficacy (the ‘natural‘ antagonist of authoritarianism) seems to be a viable tool for increasing collective political activism (e.g., joining a political party or a union), regardless of country or political leaning.

- To reach this goal of individual political activism (e.g., boycotting certain products) as well, one needs to keep a few precautions in mind and adopt country-specific approaches. Reducing authoritarianism is a double-edged sword in certain cultural contexts.